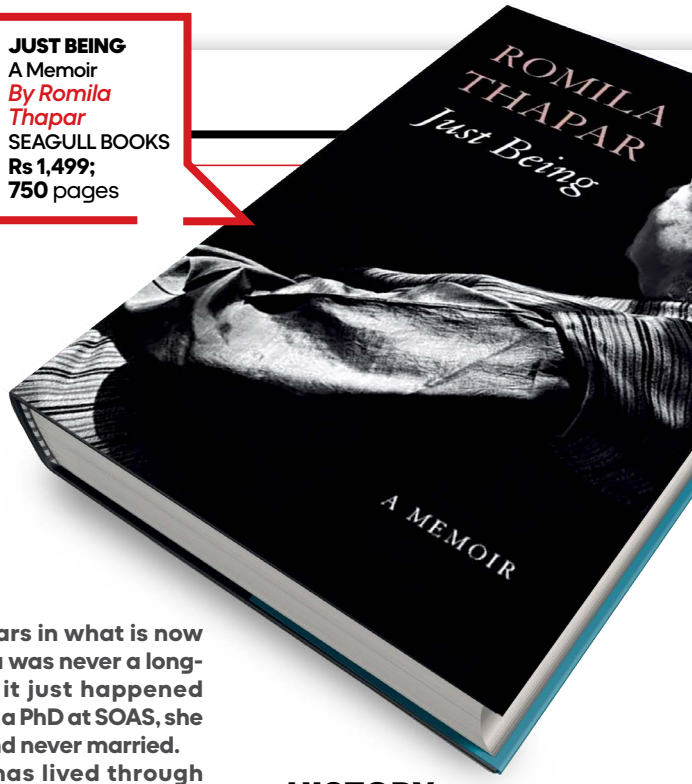
BOOKS ▼

Such a Long Journey

ROMILA THAPAR'S MEMOIR IS A CELEBRATION OF SIMPLE PLEASURES, ENRICHING FRIENDSHIPS AND LIFE LIVED ON ONE'S OWN TERMS

JUST BEING
A Memoir
By Romila Thapar
SEAGULL BOOKS
Rs 1,499;
750 pages



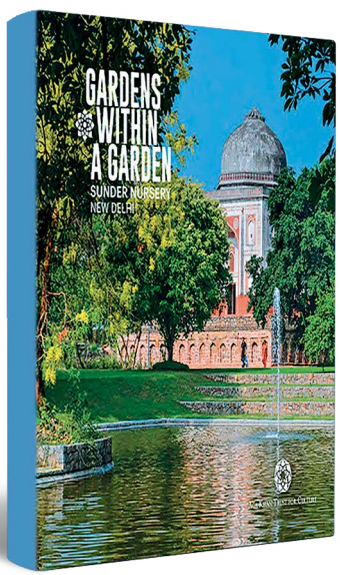
In the early 1950s, when Romila Thapar finished her undergraduate degree, her father presented her with a choice: use the money he had saved either as a dowry or for further studies. He told her he could not finance both. Thapar chose to study ancient Indian history at the School of Oriental and African Studies (SOAS) in London. The rest is academic history. *Just Being*, Thapar's memoir, is a wide-ranging account of an "unusually well-lived life", a life built on being "an autonomous woman".

Thapar was born into a Punjabi Khatri family and spent many of her privileged early years in what is now Pakistan. Academia was never a long-cherished dream, it just happened along the way. After a PhD at SOAS, she returned to India, and never married.

At 94, Thapar has lived through much: British rule, the heady days of Independence and the Emergency—not to mention the challenges of more recent years. Beyond an account of a single academic life, we get glimpses into nationhood, institution-building and disciplinary practices.

How should an academic engage with the world? How political should one's actions be? How should historians

HISTORY, THAPAR SHOWS, IS NOT MERELY DONE IN LIBRARIES AND ARCHIVES, BUT BY BEING OUT IN THE WORLD



GARDENS WITHIN A GARDEN
Sunder Nursery, New Delhi
Edited by Geeta Wahi Dua and Archana Saad Akhtar
AGA KHAN TRUST FOR CULTURE/ MAPIN
Rs 1,950; 276 pages

BOOKS ▼

PARADISE FOUND

Lavish photographs, detailed graphics and scholarly articles contextualise the remarkable revival of SUNDER NURSERY

The contiguous connection between our land and an imagined paradise was best a garden with flowing water, or so it was in the Persian imagination that arrived in Delhi via the Mughals, through both Babur and Humayun.

Now, beauty and scholarship return to the Sunderwala Mahal and Sunder Burj: the Sunder Nursery gets both an un-layering and a layered-over make-over. This marvellously mosaiced book becomes an evergreen record of the gardens surrounding a Mughal necropolis by a river, where "the flow of refreshing water, a reminder of divine blessing" continues, as the late Aga Khan IV put it. It already brings solace to over a million people who visit Sunder Nursery every year—creating unprecedented traffic problems!

The CPWD (Central Public Works Department), with rather outmoded laws and practices, even by their own admission, were bound to be more an impediment than a willing facilitator. But the might, persistence and competence of the Aga Khan Trust, led by Luis Monreal and Ratish Nanda, proved victorious. This became the first